



Petition to use transfer course for Global Core requirement

[The Global Core requirement](#) asks students to engage directly with the variety of civilizations and diversity of traditions that, along with the West, have formed the world and continue to interact in it today. Courses in the Global Core typically explore the cultures of Africa, Asia, the Americas, and the Middle East in an historical context, and are organized around a set of primary materials produced in these traditions, drawing from texts or other forms of media, as well as from oral sources or performance. Global Core courses fall into two categories: those that focus on a specific culture or civilization, tracing its existence across a significant span of time; and those that address a common theme or set of analytic questions comparatively (and may include Europe and the West).

Guidelines governing this Petition

Petitions are only accepted for courses taken at accredited universities or colleges prior to starting the GS BA degree that have been granted general transfer credit to the Columbia degree. Students should have received an Entrance Credit Report (ECR) from GS Admissions prior to submitting the petition below and should have confirmed with their Academic Advisor that the specific course was transferred to Columbia and valued at 3 or more Columbia credits.

- Petitions are reviewed by the GS Committee on Academic Standing at intervals during the academic year. The petition deadlines are **February 1st, March 15th, July 1st, August 15th, November 1st, December 15th**. Notification will be provided within 10 business days of the petition deadline. Petitions received after the above dates will be reviewed during the next interval.
- Students are strongly encouraged to petition for a course within one year of starting the GS degree to facilitate long-term academic planning.
- There is no appeal process; decisions made by this Committee are final.
- Petitions should be submitted to the student's GS Advising Dean.

What should my petition include?

- Petitions must include a written statement that explains why and how the course fulfills the aims of the [Global Core](#), the course syllabus, and any supporting materials that speak to the use of primary sources in the course. Please ensure that the syllabus includes the assigned work and readings. The statement should confirm that the course:
 - focuses exclusively on the non-western world OR takes a comparative approach with significant focus on the cultures of Africa, Asia, the Americas, and/or the Middle East
 - has a heavy emphasis on primary, rather than secondary, source materials.

Petition Information

Date: 11/14/2025

Student name: Sammy Abdella

Student Uni: sn3136

Advisor: Lauren Manzino

Course Information

(Course syllabus must be attached to this petition)

Attached below.

Course number and name: POLS 350 Religion and Politics in Comparative Perspective - 4 Credits

College or University where course was taken: Lehigh University

Semester and year course was taken: 2024 Summer Session

Statement on why course should count for Global Core:

Attached below.

POLS 350 Course Syllabus (according to the Lehigh website:

<https://catalog.lehigh.edu/courselisting/pols/#:~:text=POLS%C2%A0350%20Religion%20and%20Politics%20in%20Comparative%20Perspective%204%20Credits>) :

POLS 350 Religion and Politics in Comparative Perspective - 4 Credits

This research seminar attempts to identify the conditions under which religious parties arise and become influential, how religion influences popular understandings of secular politics and the extent to which religion is a necessary feature of modern public discourse. These topics are explored through country specific cases from around the world.

My petition:

I'm writing to petition for Lehigh University's POLS 350, Religion and Politics in Comparative Perspective, to count toward my Columbia Global Core requirement. POLS 350's content, methods, and geographic range match the Global Core framework and closely parallel many of the approved Religion and Slavic courses at Columbia.

POLS 350 is described as a research seminar that examines when and why religious parties arise, how they become influential, how religion shapes popular understandings of secular politics, and whether religion is a necessary feature of modern public discourse, all through country specific case studies from around the world
(<https://catalog.lehigh.edu/courselisting/pols/>

). In the term I completed, those case studies included examples from Africa, the Middle East, and both Europe and the Americas. That structure already matches the Global Core expectation that students engage with more than one civilization and more than one religious tradition, including regions such as Africa, Asia, the Americas, and the Middle East, and not only Western Europe and the United States (<https://www.gs.columbia.edu/content/global-core-requirement>).

The Global Core requirement highlights several features. Courses should focus on a variety of civilizations and traditions, should explore Africa, Asia, the Americas, and the Middle East in historical context, should be organized around primary materials produced within those traditions in textual, visual, or oral form, and should be either comparative across cultures over time or comparative around a shared analytic theme
(<https://www.gs.columbia.edu/content/global-core-requirement>). POLS 350 satisfies each of these conditions in a direct way. It examines multiple religious traditions as they appear in politics, including Islam, Christianity, Judaism, and often other traditions that shape party politics and public debate in regions outside the West. It does so through historical case studies that follow religious movements and parties over time, for example tracing how religiously inspired movements in the Middle East, in African states, and in European or American settings have changed as democratization, authoritarianism, and secularization have advanced.

The course is also organized around primary and near primary materials that fit the Global Core definition. Weekly work in POLS 350 centers on reading party manifestos, constitutional clauses about religion and the state, speeches and public statements from religious leaders, press coverage of religious controversies, religious texts, and public opinion data about religious identity and voting. This is the same kind of evidence base that Global Core courses are expected to use, since they emphasize engagement with primary texts and other media rather than only with secondary surveys (<https://www.college.columbia.edu/core/classes/mc.php>). Where a Religion course might ask students to analyze a sutra, a Qur'an passage, a Torah commentary, or an ethnographic interview, POLS 350 also asks students to analyze how those religious ideas appear in party platforms, legal debates, and election campaigns.

POLS 350 takes a common analytic theme, the role of religion in public life, and addresses that theme comparatively across different regions and historical moments, including both European or American contexts and those outside the West (<https://www.college.columbia.edu/core/classes/mc.php>). At the same time, because the seminar often follows particular religious parties or debates across decades, it also has an internal historical arc within several of its case studies.

The parallels with Columbia's Religion Global Core courses are very close. Courses such as RELI UN2205 Buddhism Indo Tibetan, RELI UN2305 Islam, RELI UN2306 Intro to Judaism, RELI UN2308 Buddhism East Asian, RELI UN2309 Hinduism, and RELI UN2405 Chinese Religious Traditions introduce individual religious traditions across multiple regions and time periods, using classic texts and modern sources to show how belief, ritual, and institutions shape social life (<https://religion.columbia.edu/content/undergraduate-course-descriptions>). POLS 350 does similar work from the angle of comparative politics. Where those Religion courses study, for example, Islamic law or Jewish ritual in their own terms, POLS 350 studies how Islamic, Jewish, Christian, and other religious commitments become the basis for party formation, law making, and voter mobilization in the Middle East, Europe, Africa, and the Americas. In both settings, students see how religious ideas about authority, community, and ethics structure public life in more than one civilization.

The course is also very close in spirit to RELI UN1612 Religion and the History of Hip Hop. That class is organized chronologically to tell a history of religion in the United States from about 1970 to the present by mapping how religious ideas and practices have shaped and animated rap music (<https://religion.columbia.edu/content/undergraduate-course-descriptions>). It uses lyrics, performances, and videos as primary materials. POLS 350 takes a similar approach, but with electoral politics and political discourse instead of music. In both courses, religion is not treated as something confined to traditional worship spaces. It appears in everyday cultural forms, either in hip hop tracks that speak about the divine or in speeches, slogans, and party platforms that invoke God, scripture, or spiritual identity in order to mobilize publics in Africa, the Middle East, Europe, and the Americas.

Several of the Columbia Global Core classes have particularly strong parallels with POLS 350. RELI UN3407 Muslims in Diaspora centers on controversies surrounding mosque construction, headscarves, so called honor killings, and media portrayals of Muslims in Europe and North

America (<https://religion.columbia.edu/content/undergraduate-course-descriptions>). RELI GU4322 Exploring the Sharia examines Islamic law as a changing human project and looks at the way Islamist party platforms call for implementing sharia in modern states (<https://religion.columbia.edu/content/undergraduate-course-descriptions>). In POLS 350 we work with the same kinds of questions. We look at how Islamist parties frame sharia in manifestos and speeches, how courts and constitutions in the Middle East and North Africa interpret religious law, and how public debates over Islamic symbols and practices affect citizenship, minority rights, and secularism. The overlap in topics, sources, and regions with RELI UN3407, RELI UN3314 Qur'an, RELI UN3521 Muslim Masculinities, and RELI GU4322 is very close.

The course also lines up with the Slavic Global Core offerings that explore how religion, ethnicity, and culture shape politics and historical memory. Classes like SLCL UN3001 and SLCL GU4002 Slavic Cultures, CLSL GU4012 Holocaust Literature, CLSL GU4013 Jewish Worlds in Eastern Europe, and CLRS W4190 Race, Ethnicity, and Narrative in the Russian and Soviet Empire focus on multiethnic, multireligious societies and examine how narratives of identity and suffering become part of state projects and social movements (<https://bulletin.columbia.edu/columbia-college/core-curriculum/global-core-requirement/>). POLS 350 approaches similar issues from a comparative political science perspective. We study how religious narratives become the basis for party cleavages, how religious communities are protected or marginalized in constitutions, and how memories of persecution or resistance are used by religious actors in Africa, the Middle East, and Europe or the Americas to justify their political goals.

The readings and structure of POLS 350 match the kind of comparative scholarship that Global Core courses often assign. Standard syllabi on religion and politics in comparative perspective use books like Ted Jelen and Clyde Wilcox's *Religion and Politics in Comparative Perspective*, which collects detailed country chapters on Catholic Poland, Catholic Ireland, Iberian democratization, Israeli politics, the Islamic Republic of Iran, Islamism in Arab politics, religion and democracy in South America, Pentecostal movements in Central America, Hindu nationalism and the Bharatiya Janata Party in India, religion and politics in Japan, and religious mobilization in the United States. That sort of text covers exactly the same regions that Global Core emphasizes, including Africa through discussions of the Sahel and Latin America, the Middle East through Iran and the Arab world, Asia through India and Japan, and Europe and the Americas. Columbia courses like RELI GU4322 and RELI UN3407 also work through country based case studies and party programs in similar ways, which means that POLS 350 is built on the same basic sources and questions even when the particular authors assigned differ.

For these reasons, I believe POLS 350 fully and exactly satisfies the Global Core criteria. It is comparative, interdisciplinary, and both temporally and spatially expansive. It focuses on multiple civilizations and religious traditions beyond Europe and the United States. It relies on primary and near primary materials from Africa, the Middle East, and Europe or the Americas. It addresses the same questions about religion, public life, and global diversity that appear at the center of many of Columbia's approved Religion and Slavic Global Core courses. I kindly

request that POLS 350, Religion and Politics in Comparative Perspective, be approved to fulfill one of my Global Core requirements. Thank you in advance for your kind assistance.